

Life After DEATH

Will TV change for the better now that *Kyunki...* has ended? Or will make-up, mangalsutras and madcap fights still rule?

By Kaveree Bamzai

Perhaps because it is shot a little away from Mumbai. Perhaps because it doesn't have tracking shots, the punchline repeated thrice and music designed to burst your eardrums. The sets of *Balika Vadhu*, Colors' little big serial that has been No. 1 in the Television Audience Measurement (TAM) ratings and has hastened the end of the 1,800-episode-old grandmother of all soaps, *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*, couldn't be more different. Recreated at R.C. Dairy on the Ahmedabad highway, the soap, with its 11-year-old star Avika Gor, has been on TRP charts cheek by jowl with Star Plus' *Bidaai*, the tale of two sisters against the backdrop of Agra.

Small towns (*Balika Vadhu* is set in Jodhpur, where it was shot ini-

tially in May), young girls, a gentle hand. Life in the post-*Kyunki* phase is looking very different. It's partly a function of the competition. As the share of entertainment channels has fallen (24.2 per cent of the total channel share in 2004 to 22.9 per cent in 2008) so has the share of other genres escalated (Hindi news went up from 3.7 per cent in 2004 to 4.4 per cent in 2008, while children's channels have risen from 2.7 per cent to 5.4 per cent). But it's mostly a function of the success of Colors, whose "disruptive" scheduling has proved so disconcerting that Star Plus has replaced its eight-year-long prime

(RIGHT) AVIKA GOR OF *BALIKA VADHU*; (BELOW) PARUL CHAUHAN (LEFT) AND NIKITA THUKRAL IN *BIDAAI*

PRIMARY COLOURS

24.5%

is leader Star Plus' channel share in the entertainment category followed by Colors (19.1 per cent) and Zee TV (16.8 per cent).



FALL OF FICTION

22.9%

is the share of entertainment channels in the TV viewing pie in 2008. It was 24.2 per cent in 2004.